leaders Devusinh Chauhan from Anand district in central Gujarat, Darshana Jardosh from Surat and Dr Mahendra Munjpara from Surendranagar in Saurashtra were inducted into the Union cabinet. The BJP had fared poorly in Anand and Surendranagar districts in 2017, winning only two out of seven seats and one out of five seats, respectively.

Two months later, in September 2021, the then chief minister Vijay Rupani and his cabinet were booted out in a bid to bolster the BJP's caste calculus and shed anti-incumbency concerns. Rupani was replaced by Bhupendra Patel, who had never held a ministerial post before but had built his reputation as a municipal councillor in Ahmedabad. More importantly, he was a Patidar, which sent a powerful signal to disgruntled elements in the community who had revolted against the party in 2017. Modi has maintained that Patel will be retained as CM if the BJP wins. The party is expecting a massive swing of votes in its favour from this caste group, which accounts for 16 per cent of the population and can influence the outcome in 20-30 seats.

Simultaneously, the BJP put its sitting MLAs through a process of sifting. Forty-two of them have been denied renominations, including several powerful stalwarts like Rupani and his ministerial heavyweights like Nitin Patel, Pradeepsinh Jadeja and Bhupendrasinh Chudasama. This has caused significant heartburn among those who have been dropped, with open protests in 49 seats. Some have even rebelled and are contesting as Independents against the party, forcing the BJP to expel 12 leaders for doing so. The uprising has largely been quelled for now, with the promise of plum postings in corporations or PSUs for those left out of the fray. In several cases, the party had made the contesting candidate conduct a campaign with the seat veteran who has been retired, to accord respect to the outgoing leaders and pacify their supporters.

DEFANGING THE CONGRESS

The party has been equally decisive in its moves to bleed the Congress. Much of the steam for the latter's impressive performance in 2017 was derived from the Patidar reservation movement spearheaded by Hardik Patel, who had caught the imagination of the youth. The discontent dovetailed into the prevailing anti-incumbency sentiment, costing the BJP as much as 30 per cent of the Patel vote. After the election, the Congress had made Hardik Patel working president of the state unit, only to have him soon champing at the bit at the desultory way the party was going about its election campaign. Risking the wrath of its cadres, the BJP won over Hardik Patel by getting him to join the party and then practically neutralised his influence by limiting his campaigning to a handful of seats around his hometown Viramgam, also the seat he is contesting from. Simultaneously, the BJP began targeting other Congress MLAs and luring them to its fold. Out of around the four dozen Congress leaders who have defected to the saffron camp, the BJP has fielded 17, risking dissidence in its own ranks. Among them is Alpesh Thakor, who played a prominent role for the Congress in wooing the OBCs in 2017. The Patidar Anamat Aandolan Samiti, the body under which the Patel youth were rallying for reservation in 2015, is practically defunct, though not officially wound up.

The Congress tried to hit back by wooing Naresh Patel, a businessman and founder trustee of the powerful Shree Khodaldham Temple Trust (SKTT) headquartered in Rajkot. The Leuva Patels, who constitute 80 per cent of the Patidar community, owe allegiance to the Khodaldam deity, and the temple has emerged as a powerful political axis. In January, Naresh Patel announced his desire to



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THE CONGRESS STRATEGY REMAINS AN ENIGMA. DESPITE WINNING 77 SEATS IN 2017, IT HAS DONE LITTLE TO BECOME A FORMIDABLE OPPOSITION IN THE STATE